For example, 2006 was declared the “Year of the Energy Revolution.” The “Revolution” had two sides to it: one, to improve Cuba’s energy infrastructure in order to resolve the chronic shortages and black-outs that had afflicted the country since the loss of Soviet-supplied petroleum after 1989; and two, to address sustainability by improving energy efficiency and reducing use overall. Like previous campaigns all the way back to the Literacy Campaign of 1961 (the Year of Literacy), the energy campaign called for large-scale popular participation and mobilization in pursuit of major change.[16] Green billboards exhorted Cubans to save energy. The government distributed energy-efficient appliances from light bulbs and pressure cookers to stoves and refrigerators. “President Castro approached the energy situation with a micro-managed and quasi-military campaign … The advantage of this approach, rooted in a command economy, is that it consisted of rapid though simple actions. However, the weaknesses are also those of the command economy: over-riding of people’s decision-making based on their own perceived best interests, aborted gradualist learning-by-doing, and amplification of error.”[17]

A visitor described the refrigerator delivery in a Havana neighborhood. “A megaphone woke me, and I went quickly to the door. The entire neighborhood – children, adults and grandparents – was congregated around an old man shouting: ‘¡Compañeros! ¡Compañeros! We require that all men in the quarter cooperate with the new mission of our Energy Revolution!’… From that moment on, not a single door closed until late in the evening when the task was done.”[18]

There were other changes in late 2005 that imposed more controls on the market. On October 17, Havana’s gas stations were taken over by specially trained social workers. Gas station operators, Castro charged, had been pilfering supplies and selling gasoline illegally, pocketing the profits. The same day, the military was placed in charge of the Port of Havana – again, to combat corruption. In November, the police raided farmers’ markets, targeting farmers who were selling produce without first fulfilling their obligations to the state. Later that month, illegal